

FREE GUIDE · @BUILDWITHABINASH

The Mistake-Free ITR Filing Checklist

For salaried employees

A simple, step-by-step guide · FY 2025-26 · Assessment Year 2026-27

Save this. Tick each box. File clean.

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DEADLINE – 31 JULY 2026

The last date to file and e-verify for salaried employees (no tax audit). Missed it? A belated return is allowed until 31 December 2026 – but with a late fee and interest.

STEP 0 · BEFORE YOU START (DO THIS FIRST)

- ☐ Link PAN with Aadhaar. If they aren't linked your PAN turns 'inoperative' – you can still file, but your refund is withheld, TDS is deducted at a higher rate, and TDS credit may not reflect. Check status under Profile on the portal.
- ☐ Pre-validate your bank account on incometax.gov.in (My Profile → My Bank Account). Refunds are 100% electronic – an unvalidated account means the refund fails. Make sure the name, PAN, mobile and email match your bank records.
- ☐ Keep your registered mobile handy for the Aadhaar OTP you'll use to e-verify.

STEP 1 · GATHER YOUR DOCUMENTS

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ PAN & Aadhaar | ☐ Interest certificates (savings & FD) |
| ☐ Form 16 from your employer | ☐ Capital gains statement (if you sold shares / mutual funds) |
| ☐ Form 26AS (tax credit statement) | ☐ Home loan interest certificate (if any) |
| ☐ AIS / TIS (Annual Information Statement) | ☐ Rent receipts / HRA & 80C, 80D proofs (old regime only) |
| ☐ Bank account statements | |

WHERE TO GET THEM

Form 26AS and AIS are free on incometax.gov.in after you log in – download both. They're the backbone of the next step.

STEP 2 · RECONCILE BEFORE YOU FILE

- ☐ Open your AIS and Form 26AS next to your Form 16 and bank statements.
- ☐ Match every entry – salary, TDS, FD interest, dividends, mutual fund sales, any side income.
- ☐ Found a mismatch? Fix or explain it before filing, not after.

WATCH OUT

This is the step most people skip – and the #1 reason for tax notices. Savings and FD interest already show in your AIS; if your return doesn't match, expect a notice.

STEP 3 · PICK THE RIGHT ITR FORM

As a salaried person you'll almost always use ITR-1 or ITR-2. The moment you add freelance or business income you move to ITR-3 or ITR-4 – and your due date shifts to 31 Aug 2026.

Form	Who files it	Due date
ITR-1 (Sahaj)	Resident salaried / pensioner, total income up to ₹50 lakh, up to 2 house properties, and other sources. LTCG u/s 112A up to ₹1.25 lakh allowed (only if no capital losses to carry forward).	31 Jul 2026
ITR-2	Salaried with capital gains beyond ITR-1 limits, capital losses to carry forward, more than 2 house properties, foreign income / assets, income above ₹50 lakh, or a company director – no business income.	31 Jul 2026
ITR-3	Income from a business or profession (incl. F&O trading, or salary + business with books of account).	31 Aug 2026
ITR-4 (Sugam)	Presumptive scheme (Sec 44AD / 44ADA / 44AE), total income up to ₹50 lakh – common for freelancers & consultants.	31 Aug 2026

Firms, LLPs, companies and trusts use ITR-5 / ITR-6 / ITR-7. If a tax audit applies to you, the due date is 31 Oct 2026 and it replaces the dates above.

STEP 4 · CHOOSE YOUR TAX REGIME CAREFULLY

The new regime is the default. Salaried people with no business income can simply pick the old regime inside the ITR – no separate form needed.

	New regime (default)	Old regime
Standard deduction	₹75,000	₹50,000
HRA, 80C, 80D, home-loan interest, NPS 80CCD(1B)	Mostly not allowed	Allowed – 80C up to ₹1.5L, home-loan interest up to ₹2L, 80D, HRA, NPS extra ₹50K
Zero-tax threshold	Income up to ₹12 lakh → nil tax (Sec 87A rebate up to ₹60,000). With the ₹75,000 standard deduction, salary up to ₹12.75 lakh can be tax-free.	Depends on how much you claim in deductions.

DON'T GUESS – CALCULATE

Use the free Tax Calculator on incometax.gov.in, run both regimes, and pick whichever gives the lower tax. Big deductions (HRA + home loan + 80C) → old often wins; if not, new usually wins.

BONUS · DEDUCTIONS CHEAT-SHEET (OLD REGIME)

If the old regime works out cheaper for you, here's where the savings come from. These mostly apply under the old regime only.

Section	What it covers	Max limit / year
Standard deduction	Flat deduction for every salaried person & pensioner	₹50,000 (old) · ₹75,000 (new)
80C	EPF, PPF, ELSS, life insurance, kids' tuition, home-loan principal	₹1,50,000
80CCD(1B)	NPS – extra, over and above 80C	₹50,000
80D	Health insurance premium (self & family)	₹25,000 (+ up to ₹50,000 for senior-citizen parents)
Sec 24(b)	Home-loan interest (self-occupied house)	₹2,00,000
80TTA	Savings-account interest	₹10,000 (₹50,000 for seniors under 80TTB)
HRA	House rent, if your salary includes HRA	As per the HRA formula

STEP 5 · FILE YOUR RETURN

- ☐ Log in at incometax.gov.in and start filing for AY 2026-27.
- ☐ Check the pre-filled data against your own documents – don't assume it's correct.
- ☐ Enter your deductions (if old regime) and review the tax summary.
- ☐ If any tax is still payable, pay the self-assessment tax first, then submit.

STEP 6 · e-VERIFY WITHIN 30 DAYS (THE STEP PEOPLE FORGET)

FILING IS NOT THE FINISH LINE

A return that isn't verified within 30 days of filing is treated as invalid – as if you never filed. It's like posting a letter without the stamp.

- ☐ e-Verify instantly using Aadhaar OTP, net banking, or bank / demat EVC.
- ☐ No online option? Post the signed ITR-V to: CPC, Income Tax Department, Bengaluru – 560500.
- ☐ Track your refund status on the portal after verification.

REFUND NOT SHOWING UP?

Check all four: (1) PAN is linked with Aadhaar, (2) your bank account is pre-validated and the name matches your PAN, (3) the return is e-verified, (4) no outstanding tax demand. Then track it under Services → Refund / Demand Status.

WHAT IT COSTS TO MISS 31 JULY

Situation	Cost
Late filing fee – income up to ₹5 lakh (Sec 234F)	₹1,000
Late filing fee – income above ₹5 lakh (Sec 234F)	₹5,000
Interest on unpaid tax (Sec 234A)	1% per month (or part of a month)
Belated / revised return window	Until 31 Dec 2026

KEY DATES AT A GLANCE (AY 2026-27)

Date	What happens
31 Jul 2026	File and e-verify – salaried & other non-audit filers (ITR-1 / ITR-2)
31 Aug 2026	Non-audit business / professional filers (ITR-3 / ITR-4)
31 Oct 2026	Taxpayers whose accounts need a tax audit
+30 days	e-verify within 30 days of filing, or the return becomes invalid
31 Dec 2026	Last date for a belated or revised return (with late fee)

HANDY OFFICIAL LINKS (ALL FREE ON incometax.gov.in)

- ☐ File / e-verify your return: eportal.incometax.gov.in
- ☐ Link PAN with Aadhaar: incometaxindia.gov.in/tax-services/link-aadhaar
- ☐ Tax slabs, deductions & regime info (salaried): incometax.gov.in
- ☐ e-verification (30-day rule) FAQs: incometax.gov.in → e-verify your return
- ☐ View AIS & Form 26AS, pre-validate bank, e-Pay Tax: after login on the e-filing portal

TOP MISTAKES TO AVOID

- ☐ Not matching your return with AIS & 26AS
- ☐ Forgetting savings / FD interest income
- ☐ Picking a regime without comparing both
- ☐ Choosing the wrong ITR form
- ☐ Not e-verifying within 30 days
- ☐ Bank account not pre-validated → refund fails
- ☐ PAN not linked with Aadhaar
- ☐ Waiting till the last day (portal gets slow)

Tick every box above and you've filed clean.

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FOLLOW FOR MORE

Follow [@buildwithabinash](#) for finance, made simple. Save this checklist and share it with a friend who's filing this year.

Sources & disclaimer

Verified July 2026 against the Income Tax Department (incometax.gov.in): ITR due dates, e-verification (30-day) FAQs, ITR-1 / ITR-2 eligibility (incl. the AY 2026-27 two-house-property and LTCG u/s 112A changes), deduction limits, and PAN–Aadhaar / bank pre-validation rules; Finance Act 2026 (ITR-3 / ITR-4 non-audit due date 31 Aug 2026).

This checklist is general educational information for salaried individuals for FY 2025-26 (AY 2026-27) under the Income-tax Act, 1961. (The new Income-tax Act, 2025 applies from FY 2026-27 onwards, so it doesn't affect this year's return.) It is not tax advice – rules and dates can change, so always confirm on incometax.gov.in and consult a qualified tax professional for your situation.